

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN PALAU

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the land and reefs of Palau, and one state's people showed that a community armed with good science can persuade its own leaders to ban a destructive practice outright. When scientists demonstrated that clearing the land — and especially the mangroves along the shore — was sending sediment onto the reefs and harming the fish that feed Palauan families, the people of one state did something practical and effective: they took that evidence to their own state government and lobbied until the clearing of mangroves was banned. And that was not a lone act. Across the largest island, community after community, working together through an alliance and drawing on Palau's own tradition of the temporary moratorium the islands call "bul," established their own protected areas on the land, turning scientific understanding and cultural practice into lasting protection for the forests, the watersheds, and the reefs below them. The destructive clearing was stopped where the community made its case; the protected areas hold. It is worth setting down what those communities actually did, because it shows how ordinary people turn understanding into protection. The harm was not obvious at first: clearing land and cutting mangroves seemed a local matter, until reef scientists showed that the sediment washing off the cleared ground was settling on the reefs offshore, smothering the corals and thinning the fish that Palauan families rely on for food. Once that link between the land and the sea was shown clearly, the community had something a mere complaint never has — evidence a leader could act on. They took it to the people closest to them with the power to respond, their own state government and their traditional chiefs, rather than to a distant national office or a foreign company, and they asked for a concrete remedy: ban the clearing, protect the watershed. And because the request was grounded in solid science, rooted in the community, and carried through the authorities the community itself respects, it was granted.

The Palauan story teaches two things about stopping destructive projects here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly and up front. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Palauan, and it protected the land and the reefs. **A community can take solid scientific evidence of harm — how a clearing or a development damages the reefs, fish, and water it depends on — to its own state and traditional leaders, and, working through them and through Palau's tradition of community-owned protection and the moratorium of bul, ban the destructive practice and place the land under lasting protection.** That power — the science, the community, the state and traditional leaders, and the tradition of local protection — is Palau's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What makes this lever unusual, and worth understanding precisely, is where it applies pressure. It does not try to out-fight a developer in a national court or out-spend a foreign investor; it works through the authorities closest to the community — the state and the chiefs — who are both reachable and genuinely powerful over local land, and it arms the community's appeal with something those authorities can act on: solid science and the legitimacy of custom. A distant national government may be hard for a small community to move, and a foreign company harder still; but a state government and a council of chiefs are neighbours, answerable to the community, and receptive to evidence that the reefs and fisheries their own people depend on are being harmed. The community's task is therefore to bring the science and the custom to the leaders who are both close and

capable, and ask for a concrete, lasting protection — which is exactly what the Airai and Babeldaob communities did.

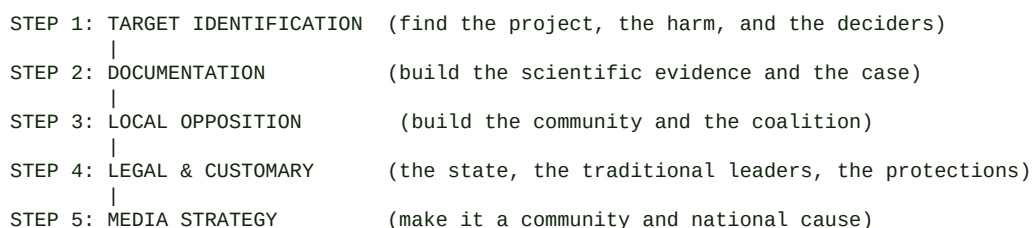
But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them; it places them first. The community-driven wins here are **local and modest** — a state ban on clearing, community protected areas — not the halting of a huge national project, and a community should not expect one campaign to stop everything. Palau's **largest** conservation victories — the vast marine sanctuary, the shark sanctuary — were **led by national leaders and law**, not by grassroots opposition, so a community here depends heavily on **supportive leaders and the authority of the traditional chiefs**, which is a real strength but also a real limit. And this is a **small nation** facing large forces — foreign investment, a flood of tourism, a changing climate — against which a single community's leverage is bounded, and many wins are partial. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of science-backed community advocacy through local and traditional authority — and the modest scale, the reliance on supportive leaders, and the hard limits of a small nation that qualify it. These qualifications are not footnotes; they are part of an honest picture, and a community should weigh them before it begins. The modest scale matters: banning a clearing and protecting a watershed are real, lasting gains, but they are not the same as halting a national mega-project, and a community that expects one campaign to stop everything will be discouraged. The reliance on supportive leaders matters too: Palau's greatest conservation achievements came from national leaders and law, and even the local wins depended on states and chiefs willing to act, so a community whose leaders are unwilling faces a harder road and must patiently win them over. And the limits of a small nation are real: against foreign investment, a flood of tourism, and a changing climate, a single community's leverage is bounded, and many gains are partial. An honest campaign here aims to protect what it can, and counts a watershed and a reef defended as a real victory even when the larger forces cannot all be turned. If your fight, too, is to protect the land and reefs you depend on, and you can bring evidence to leaders who may listen, this is the guide for it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They watch the land cleared and the reef decline and assume "the developer has the permits and the leaders have decided and nothing can be done," and never gather the evidence, never take it to their state and chiefs, never establish the protection. They generate private worry without organised advocacy. The gap between a clearing stopped and one allowed is rarely apathy — Palauans proved a community will act to protect its reefs. It is method: knowing how to marshal the science, work through the state and the traditional leaders, and secure lasting protection.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Palauan system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a clearing, a dredging, a resort, or another destructive project:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The science feeds the advocacy and the protection at once; the community grows; a protected area or a state ban is both a win and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a clearing

banned, a watershed protected, a reef defended. The Airai and Babeldaob communities did exactly this — they marshalled the science, worked through their states and chiefs, and established lasting protection.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Palau's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The science.** Solid **scientific evidence of harm** — how a clearing or development damages the reefs, fish, and water the community depends on — is powerful, as the reef science was in Airai. This is the lever that most distinguishes a Palauan fight of this kind, and it rewards close attention. In a place where the sea feeds the people and the reefs are a source of national pride, evidence that a project harms the reefs and the fishery is not an abstraction — it speaks to food, livelihood, and identity, and it gives the state and the chiefs a clear, defensible reason to act. Solid science also does something a protest cannot: it converts a contested opinion into a demonstrated fact, one a leader can stand behind and a proponent finds hard to dismiss. The community that can show, with credible reef and watershed science, exactly how a clearing or development damages the sea it depends on has found the argument that moves Palau's decision-makers most reliably, as the science of sediment and reefs moved Airai to act.
- **The state and traditional leaders.** Palau's **state governments and traditional chiefs** are close to the community and can ban a practice or protect an area, as Airai's state did.
- **The tradition of bul and local protection.** Palau's tradition of the **moratorium (bul)** and **community-owned protected areas** is a legitimate, culturally-grounded tool, as it grounded the protected areas.
- **The link between land and reef.** Showing that **protecting the land protects the reef and the fish** the community lives on is a uniquely Palauan and persuasive argument.
- **The national and international attention.** Palau's fame as a **conservation leader** draws attention and allies that reinforce a community's case.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver a grand or complete win. The community wins here are **modest and local**; the biggest victories are **leader-led**; and this is a **small nation** with limited leverage against large forces. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them first — and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Palau offers — the science, the state and traditional leaders, the tradition of local protection, and the land-and-reef link — as Palauan communities used them to ban a destructive clearing and protect their watersheds.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the project — or the leverage — is weakest. And map the science and the leaders you can reach, because in Palau a destructive project is often best stopped by bringing solid evidence to the state and traditional leaders closest to the community.

The Levels of Decision

A Palauan development runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The state government. The **state** — Palau's sixteen states are close to their communities — permits much local land use and can ban a practice or protect an area, as Airai state banned mangrove clearing. It is worth grasping why the state, rather than the national government, is so often the better first target in a fight like this. Palau's states are small, close to their communities, and hold real power over local land use, so a community's appeal reaches decision-makers who are neighbours and who feel the community's concerns directly — and who can act quickly, without the delay and distance of national politics. A state that is shown solid evidence of harm to its own people's reefs and fisheries has both the power and the incentive to respond with a ban or a refusal. This is why so much of the distinctive Palauan strategy is organised around bringing the science to the state closest to the community, rather than only petitioning a distant national office.

The traditional leaders. The **traditional chiefs** hold real authority and custom, advise leaders, and can invoke the moratorium of **bul**, as the tradition grounds Palau's protections.

The national government and law. The **national government** and the **Protected Areas Network** provide the framework that recognises and supports local protection, as the network supports community-owned areas.

The community and the coalition. The **community**, its NGOs, and its scientists are the force that gathers the evidence and makes the case, as the reef science and the watershed alliance did.

The science and the world. The **scientific evidence** and Palau's **international standing** as a conservation leader are levers, persuading leaders and drawing allies.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a plan and a permit, through clearing or construction, toward harm to the land and reefs — with the **community's evidence, the state, the traditional leaders, and lasting protection** able to intervene. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in**, and the science brought to the state and chiefs is the distinctive Palauan door. The distinctive levers are the **science**, the **state and traditional leaders**, the **tradition of local protection**, and the **land-and-reef link**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what harm the science can show, which state and traditional leaders can act**, and **whether the area can be placed under lasting protection**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Harm, and the Deciders

Behind a project stand a proponent and the state that permits it. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly here — **what harm the project does to the reefs, fish, and water the community depends on, which state and traditional leaders have authority over it, whether it can be banned or the area protected**, and **who can supply the science**. Two questions unlock most Palauan fights of this kind: **What harm can solid science show — especially to the reefs and fish the community lives on?** and **Which state and traditional leaders can ban the practice or protect the area?** The science and the leaders close to the community are, together, the heart of most such campaigns. These two work together in a way particular to the fight here: the science supplies the demonstrated harm — the sediment on the reef, the thinning catch — and the closeness of the state and chiefs supplies decision-makers both willing and able to act on it. A campaign that has the science but takes it only to distant or indifferent authorities has evidence no one will use; one that has reachable leaders but no solid evidence has access without a compelling case. Joined together — credible science of harm to the reef, brought to the state and chiefs close to the community — they make a ban or a protection the natural response, because the people asked are both

moved by the harm to their own community's waters and empowered to do something about it. That is the combination Airai and Babeldaob assembled, and it is why a clearing was banned and watersheds protected.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **state governments**; the **traditional chiefs** and the **Council of Chiefs**; the **Protected Areas Network** and the framework of local protection; the **scientists** and research bodies who document the harm; the **community NGOs and alliances**; and the **national and international conservation world** that watches Palau. In Palau, the **science, the state and traditional leaders, the tradition of local protection, and the land-and-reef link** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project shown by good science to harm the reefs, opposed by a community, and set against the authority of the state and the chiefs rarely proceeds unopposed — as the mangrove clearing did not in Airai.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Palauan and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether **solid science can show harm** to the resources the community depends on, whether **state and traditional leaders can be persuaded to act**, whether the **area can be placed under lasting protection**, and whether the **community unites**. Where the science is solid and the leaders are reachable, the levers here are real, as Airai shows; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that these wins are modest and local, that the biggest victories are leader-led, and that a small nation's leverage is limited.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–10%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Solid science of harm	45–70%	weeks–months	low–moderate	The case leaders can act on
Persuading state & traditional leaders	45–70%	months	low	A practice banned; an area protected
Establishing lasting protection	40–65%	months	low	The land placed under protection
Community unity & coalition	45–70%	weeks–months	low	A community that acts together
The land-and-reef argument	40–65%	ongoing	low	The community persuaded it must act
Media & public pressure	35–60%	ongoing	low	A community and national cause
All steps (solid science, reachable leaders)	45–70%	months	moderate	A clearing banned; a watershed protected
All steps (weak science / distant deciders)	20–45%	months	moderate	Delay; a record; the case made

A note on cost: the most powerful Palauan levers — a united community, the authority of the state and chiefs, the tradition of local protection — cost mainly organising and persistence. The one expense that most changes outcomes is the science, and much of it can be supplied by Palau's research bodies and conservation partners, as reef scientists supplied the Airai case. Bring solid evidence to leaders who can act, and count the modest scale honestly.

1. **The science** — Palau's foundation; the solid evidence of harm, as the reef science was in Airai.
2. **The state and traditional leaders** — the distinctive lever; the authority close to the community that can act.
3. **The lasting protection** — the community-owned protected area or ban that holds.
4. **The community unity** — the community that gathers the evidence and makes the case.
5. **The land-and-reef link** — the argument that persuades the community and the leaders to act.

What Palauan Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Solid science persuades** — evidence of harm to the reefs and fish moves leaders and communities. **State and traditional leaders can act** — authority close to the community can ban a practice or protect an area. **Local protection holds** — a community-owned protected area or a ban lasts. **The land-and-reef link convinces** — showing that protecting the land protects the fish is uniquely persuasive here. **But the wins are modest and the biggest are leader-led** — a community should aim realistically. The honest way to hold this is to separate the two kinds of Palauan win. The grand, nation-scale victories — the vast marine sanctuary, the shark sanctuary, the ban on destructive trawling — were achieved by national leaders and law, and a community should not measure itself against them or expect to replicate them from below. The community-scale wins — a state banning a harmful clearing, a village placing its watershed under protection — are the ones a determined community can actually secure, and they are real and lasting. Aiming for the second kind, patiently and well, is how communities here succeed; mistaking the first kind for the ordinary measure of success is how they grow discouraged. The through-line: **marshal the science; work through the state and traditional leaders; establish lasting protection; unite the community; make the land-and-reef case — because in Palau a community with solid evidence and reachable leaders can ban a destructive clearing and protect its watershed, though the wins are local and a small nation's leverage limited.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact project and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is often the science and the leaders close to the community. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the clearing, which the science shows will smother our reef and cut our catch, which our state and chiefs can ban, and whose land we can place under protection" is a campaign — the kind that stopped the clearing in Airai. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What harm can the science show? This is the first Palauan question of this kind. What **solid scientific evidence** can be gathered of harm to the reefs, fish, and water the community depends on, as the reef science showed in Airai. Assess this honestly and precisely at the outset, because in Palau the solidity of the science is what most determines the strength of a campaign. A vague claim of harm, or a concern the community feels but cannot demonstrate, gives the state and chiefs little to act on and the proponent much to dispute. But credible, specific evidence — measured sediment, traced runoff, a documented decline in the reef and the catch — gives the authorities a defensible reason to ban or protect, as the reef science did in Airai. A community should therefore establish, first, what harm can actually be shown and who can help show it, for the strength of the science is the foundation on which the appeal to the leaders and every other lever depends.

2. Which state and traditional leaders can act? Which **state government and traditional chiefs** have authority over the project and could ban it or protect the area, as Airai's state did.

3. Can the area be protected? Can the land be placed under **lasting protection** — a community-owned protected area, a ban — as the watershed areas were.

4. Who can supply the science and the support? Which **research bodies and conservation partners** can document the harm, as reef scientists did. This question rewards early attention, because in Palau the scientific documentation is both the decisive lever and the part a community can least supply alone. A

community knows its reef and its declining catch, but turning that knowledge into evidence a state or a chief can act on — and a proponent cannot easily dismiss — usually needs the reef and watershed scientists whose work carried the Airai case. Establishing early which research bodies and conservation partners can document the harm therefore shapes what the whole campaign can attempt, and a clear, answerable question presented to them is often the most productive first step a community can take.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and what is at stake? Which proponent and officials are behind it, who profits; and what the project does to the reefs, the fish, the water, and the community's way of life.

A Worked Example

Suppose a development plans to clear land near the shore, threatening the reef and the fishery below with sediment.

Working the five questions: **what harm can the science show? Which state and chiefs can act? Can the area be protected? Who supplies the science?** And the deciders are the proponent and the state, with the science, the state and traditional leaders, and lasting protection as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the permit is granted and nothing can be done" to a target list: marshal the science; work through the state and chiefs; establish protection; supply the evidence; make the land-and-reef case. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how the clearing was banned in Airai. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a sense that the permit is granted and nothing can be done into a set of concrete, workable tasks — marshal the science, work through the state and chiefs, establish protection, supply the evidence, make the land-and-reef case — each tied to a specific lever that Palau genuinely provides. That reframing, from resignation before a permitted project to a plan built on the community's science and its own leaders, is the difference the questions make, and the first two — what harm can the science show, and which leaders can act — often decide how strong a hand the campaign holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. The state, the chiefs, a scientist, and the community all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Palau, the scientific proof of harm to the reefs and fish is precisely what a campaign turns into a ban or a protection, so document it well and early. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Permit, and the Deciders

Get the documents the case turns on. Identify the **project, its proponent, and its permit**; and establish **which state and traditional leaders** have authority over it, and **what protection framework** — the Protected Areas Network, a state ban — could apply. Establish the deciders and the project precisely, because they are who the science must persuade.

Layer 2: The Harm — the Science of Reef and Land

Document the reality the project understates, and here the **science is central**. Record, with the help of research bodies, **how the project harms the reefs, fish, and water** — the sediment from clearing, the runoff, the damage to the fishery — as reef science showed how land clearing smothered Airai's reefs. Record the **value** of what is at stake — the reef, the fishery, the watershed, the way of life — and the

land-and-reef link that shows protecting the land protects the sea. This is the evidence that persuades leaders and community alike. The science of the land-and-reef link, in particular, deserves to be documented with care, because it is both the most persuasive and the least obvious part of the case. Palauans have always understood the sea; the harder thing to show, and the thing that changed minds in Airai, is that clearing the land — ground far from the water's edge, or the mangroves along the shore — sends sediment down the watershed and onto the reefs, harming the corals and the fish. Documenting that connection concretely, with the help of reef and watershed scientists, turns a development that looks purely terrestrial into a demonstrated threat to the sea the community depends on, and gives the state and the chiefs a reason grounded in the community's own deepest concern. A well-documented land-and-reef link is often the single most decisive piece of evidence a Palauan campaign can hold.

Layer 3: The Science, the Authority, and the Protection

Finally, document the case. Does the **science** solidly show harm? Which **state and traditional leaders** can act on it? And can the area be placed under **lasting protection**? Each is a separate ground — for the state, the chiefs, the community, and the partners — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away and that points to a concrete remedy: a ban, a protected area. This is the layer that most often decides Palauan fights of this kind, because here harm is scientifically shown, an authority close to the community is identified who can act, and a lasting protection is proposed — exactly the case that banned the clearing in Airai, where solid reef science brought to a reachable state government turned understanding into a ban. Assembling all three grounds together — the science, the authority, and the protection — is what gives a Palauan case its force, because each does a different job and they reinforce one another: the science supplies the demonstrated harm, the state and chiefs supply the power to act on it, and the protected area or ban supplies a concrete, lasting remedy the leaders can grant. A campaign that shows harm but names no authority who can act, or that reaches the leaders but proposes no clear remedy, leaves the decision-makers with a problem and no solution. Shown together — a scientifically demonstrated harm, an authority close to the community with power to act, and a concrete protection to grant — they make the ban or the protected area the natural response, which is how understanding became a ban in Airai.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Palauan cases of this kind, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the harm, the authority, and the protection.

The Project, the Science, and the Paper Trail

- **The project and permit** — what is planned, by whom, and under what authority.
- **The state and traditional authority** — who has power over the land and the practice.
- **The scientific evidence** — how the project harms the reefs, fish, and water.
- **The land-and-reef link** — how protecting the land protects the sea and the fishery.
- **The protection framework** — the Protected Areas Network, a state ban, the tradition of bul.

How to Get Them

The project and permit are matters of state and national record, obtainable from the relevant authorities, and identifying the **state and traditional leaders** with power over the land is the ground on which the campaign stands. The scientific evidence is the heart of the case, and much of it can be supplied by **Palau's research**

bodies and conservation partners, whose reef and watershed science can show harm to scientific standard, as such science showed the impact of clearing on Airai's reefs. And the protection framework — the Protected Areas Network, the tradition of bul — is a matter of national and customary practice that a community can invoke, as communities did to establish their watershed areas. Lean on **allies**: the research institutions, the conservation NGOs, the watershed alliances, and the traditional leaders whose authority carries weight. Move promptly, and keep your record clear.

The Ground Evidence

- **The scientific harm** — the sediment, the runoff, the damage to reef and fishery.
- **The authority to act** — the state and traditional leaders who can ban or protect.
- **The land-and-reef link** — the evidence that land protection protects the sea.
- **The value at stake** — the reef, the fishery, the watershed, the way of life.
- **The protection available** — the community-owned protected area or ban that could hold.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the project, the permit, the science, and every step of the fight — the spine of any appeal to the state, the chiefs, or the community. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced fast. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a scientist, a state official, a chief, and a partner all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the proponent pushes back. In Palau, the campaign with the clearer case — above all the most solid science of harm and the clearest path to a ban or protection — is very often the one that protects the land and the reef, as Airai's did.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COMMUNITY AND THE COALITION

Evidence does not win on its own. A united community and a broad coalition do — and in Palau, the Airai and Babeldaob communities prove that a community that marshals the science and works together through its states and chiefs can ban a destructive practice and protect its watersheds. A campaign's strength here is that unity and that partnership: a community that acts together, backed by science and carried through its own leaders.

Phase 1: The Core and the Community

Start with a committed core rooted in the **affected community and local leaders**, and do the distinctively Palauan first work: **connect the community to the science**, so people see how a clearing or development harms the reefs and fish they depend on, as reef science persuaded Airai's people to act. Assign roles — the science, the advocacy to the state and chiefs, the protection, media, and liaison with partners. Agree on the goal — the practice banned, the area protected — and the remedy you will seek. Being clear about the remedy from the start matters more here than in many places, because the authorities a Palauan campaign appeals to — the state, the chiefs — act by granting concrete things: a ban on a practice, a refusal of a permit, an area placed under protection. A community that knows exactly what it is asking for, and can name the specific ban or protection it seeks, gives those authorities something definite to grant and is far more likely to win than one that voices only opposition. Decide early what a win looks like in concrete terms, and build the whole campaign toward securing it.

Phase 2: The Science, the Leaders, and the Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately, and build the partnership with the **science and the leaders** that is Palau's distinctive strength, as reef scientists and the state carried the Airai case. Bring in the **whole community and its clubs and organisations**, whose unity makes the case strong; the **research bodies and conservation partners**, whose science documents the harm; the **state government and the traditional chiefs**, whose authority can ban and protect; the **watershed alliances and protected-area networks**, whose model offers lasting protection; and the **national and international conservation world** that watches Palau. The Airai and Babeldaob campaigns drew their power from exactly this partnership — the community, the science, the leaders — which is precisely the spread a Palauan campaign of this kind needs. The partnership with research bodies deserves particular emphasis, because in Palau the science is both the decisive lever and the piece a community is least able to supply on its own. A community knows its reef and its catch, but documenting the harm to scientific standard — measuring the sediment, tracing the runoff, linking the land clearing to the reef decline — usually requires the reef and watershed scientists whose work made the Airai case. A community should therefore reach out early to Palau's research institutions and conservation partners, presenting a clear question their evidence can answer, for their science is what turns the community's concern into a case the state and chiefs can act on. This partnership between local knowledge and formal science is at the heart of how Palauan communities protect their reefs.

A worked coalition example. Facing a harmful clearing, the community and its clubs unite; research bodies document the reef harm; the state government and chiefs are brought to act; and a watershed alliance offers a protected-area model. No single group could ban a practice and protect a watershed; together they cover the community, the science, and the authority — the model Airai and Babeldaob built. The lesson of that model is that no single part of a coalition needs to be able to win alone; what matters is that, between them, the parts cover every front a Palauan fight of this kind requires — the community to make the case its own, the scientists to prove the harm, the state and chiefs to grant the remedy, and the watershed alliances to supply a model of lasting protection. A community that maps these fronts and finds a partner for each builds something far stronger than the sum of its parts, and far harder for a proponent to dismiss than any one group acting alone.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

A campaign can run for months or years, so endurance matters. Meet on a rhythm that can be kept. Renew the coalition, bringing in new people as others tire. Give people concrete tasks — the science, the advocacy, the protection, liaison with partners. Mark the wins that come — a study completed, a chief persuaded, a state moving, an area protected — because in a long fight morale is sustained by real gains. Keep the coalition broad, and guard against the **modest scale** of what one campaign can achieve, the **length of the fight**, and the honest fact that the **biggest wins are leader-led**, so a community must patiently win its leaders. Value a local win: a watershed protected is a real and lasting gain. Hold this honestly in view from the start, because the shape of success here is unusual and can be misread as failure. A single campaign will not turn back every pressure on a small nation's land and reefs; what it can do is protect a particular watershed, ban a particular harmful practice, place a particular area under lasting care — real, durable gains that a campaign measuring itself only against the whole would overlook. Palau's conservation has been built precisely from such local protections, watershed by watershed and reef by reef, and a community that secures one has both protected something irreplaceable and added to a growing network that protects more. Value the local win, and build the next upon it.

Phase 4: The Community, the Science, and the Leaders

Here is Palau's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, the **community and the science**: unite the community and arm it with **solid scientific evidence** of harm, so the case is both broad and grounded, as it was in Airai. Second, and decisively, the **state and traditional leaders**: carry the science to the **state government and the chiefs**, and invoke the tradition of **local protection and bul**, so authority close to the community acts, as Airai's state banned the clearing and communities protected their watersheds. Keep it **united, evidence-based, and worked through the leaders**, because in Palau it is a community that acts together, brings solid science, and wins over its own state and chiefs that bans a destructive practice and protects its land — as the Airai and Babeldaob communities did.

STEP 4: LEGAL & CUSTOMARY CHALLENGES — THE STATE, THE TRADITIONAL LEADERS, AND THE PROTECTIONS

Palau's states, its traditional authority, its Protected Areas Network, and — distinctively — its tradition of community-owned protection and the moratorium of bul are a real toolkit. You do not need to win in a national court to win: a state ban, a chief's authority invoked, an area placed under lasting protection — each is a real gain, and together they can stop a destructive project. Engage partners and leaders early — but understand the tools.

The State and Its Power to Ban and Permit

The first lever is the **state government's power over local land use**. Palau's states are close to their communities and control much local development, and a **state can ban a destructive practice or refuse a permit**, as Airai state banned mangrove clearing. Bring the science to the state; it is the authority most able to act quickly and locally. It is worth being precise about why the state is often the most effective place to seek a remedy. Because Palau's states are small and close to their communities, a state government can respond to a local harm far faster than a national process, and its authority over local land use is direct and real — a state can ban a practice or refuse a permit within its jurisdiction without waiting on national politics. A community that brings solid, locally-relevant evidence to its own state speaks to decision-makers who share its concerns and can act on them promptly, as Airai's state did. This is why a Palauan campaign so often begins by identifying the state authority with power over the project and building the case for it to act.

The Traditional Leaders and the Tradition of Bul

The second and most distinctive lever is the **authority of the traditional chiefs and the tradition of bul**. The chiefs hold real authority and custom, advise leaders, and can invoke **bul**, the moratorium that halts the use of a resource to let it recover, as bul grounds Palau's protections. Win the chiefs, and invoke the tradition; their authority and the legitimacy of custom carry weight the state and the community both respect. The tradition of bul deserves particular emphasis, because it is a lever peculiar to Palau and easy for an outsider to underestimate. Bul is not a quaint custom but a living practice of resource protection — a moratorium that halts the taking of a resource so it can recover — with deep legitimacy in Palauan society, and Palau's modern conservation, including its celebrated protected areas, has drawn on it explicitly. A community that frames its request in these terms is not merely making an environmental argument but invoking a respected cultural authority, one the chiefs can exercise and the community readily accepts. Aligning a campaign with the tradition of bul and the authority of the chiefs therefore gives it a legitimacy and a durability that a purely technical appeal would lack.

The Protected Areas and the Partners

The third lever is **lasting protection through the Protected Areas Network and the community-owned model**. An area placed under **community-owned protection** and recognised by the national network holds against future harm, as the watershed protected areas do. And **research bodies and conservation partners** supply the science and support that make the case, as they did for the reef and watershed work. Use them together with the state and the chiefs.

Where to Turn and With Whom

The ban goes through the **state government**; the moratorium and legitimacy through the **traditional chiefs and bul**; the lasting protection through the **Protected Areas Network and the community-owned model**; the science through the **research bodies and partners**. Get help early: these leaders and partners know the states, the custom, the network, and the science, and they will support a community with a solid, evidence-based case, as they supported Airai and Babeldaob. Help engaged early is worth far more than help sought after, and in Palau the strongest strategy marries the **community and the science** to the **state and traditional leaders and the tradition of local protection**, so that a destructive project is met by a community armed with evidence and carried through its own authorities — as the mangrove clearing was in Airai, until it was banned.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades the state, a chief, a scientist, a journalist, and the community in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that clearing the land near the shore sends sediment onto the reef and cuts the community's fish catch. That one fact becomes:

- **A scientific argument:** the evidence shows measurable harm to the reef and fishery — the case the state and chiefs can act on.
- **A state argument:** this is within the state's power to ban or refuse — the case for local action.
- **A customary argument:** the chiefs can invoke bul to protect the resource — the case grounded in tradition. Custom, here, is not weaker than law but in some ways stronger, because it carries a legitimacy the whole community already accepts.
- **A livelihood argument:** the reef feeds our families, and this harms our catch — the case that unites the community.
- **A protection argument:** this area should be placed under lasting protection — the concrete remedy. Naming the protection you seek turns a complaint into a proposal a leader can grant.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Palau the arguments that most often decide things are the **scientific** and **state/customary** ones, because they move the authorities close to the community, and the **livelihood** one, because it unites the people. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a chief can be backed and a claim made to the state can be proven; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive. And be honest about the state of the fight: acknowledge the scale is often local, and argue for the real, lasting protection a community win can secure.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The state government responds to solid evidence of local harm and its own power to ban or protect.

The traditional chiefs respond to the harm to the community's resources and the legitimacy of custom and bul.

The scientists and partners respond to a clear question their evidence can answer, and a community ready to act on it.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a community using science to save its reef from a harmful clearing.

The community needs the argument clear and close to home: our reef, our fish, our water, our future. The livelihood argument, though it moves people most, must stay anchored to the documented science if it is to serve the other fronts as well. The dependence of an island community on its reef and its catch rallies people rightly; but the same case, stated precisely — the measured sediment, the specific harm, the concrete remedy — is also what the state, the chiefs, and the partners require. A campaign that lets the livelihood argument drift into exaggeration hands the proponent an easy rebuttal and weakens the case built on the same ground. Keep the livelihood argument vivid but true, so that the concern that stirs the community and the evidence that moves the leaders are one and the same, drawn from a single reliable record.

The international conservation world responds to Palau's example and to a community protecting globally valued nature. Because this audience is moved by exactly such stakes, a campaign gains by framing its case in those terms. The international conservation community — the reef and ocean groups, the sympathetic press abroad — responds not only to the harm to a single reef but to Palau's standing as a global conservation leader and to the example of a community protecting nature the world values. A campaign that can show its reef is globally significant and its community determined speaks directly to what this community exists to support, and can draw the scientific help, the amplification, and the reinforcement that a small community cannot generate alone. Palau's conservation fame is itself a resource a local campaign can draw upon.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Palau, where a community using science to protect its reef fits the nation's proud conservation story and international coverage draws allies, coverage that carries that story is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage unites the community, moves the state and chiefs, and draws partners and attention. The reef and watershed work became part of Palau's conservation story — the science, the community, and the lasting protection.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the science and the reef. "A clearing is controversial" is not a story; "the science shows this clearing is smothering the reef our families fish, and the community is asking the state to ban it, as Airai did" is — the kind of story that fits Palau's conservation fame. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the science, the harm to the reef, the remedy — and offer a human voice and the beauty of the place: a fisher, a scientist, an image of the reef and the watershed. The specific and the local matter here: not conservation in the abstract, but this reef, these families, this catch that is thinning, and the clearing upstream that the science ties to it. In Palau the story of a community using knowledge and custom to protect its reef is one the nation and the world respond to.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **The community and local voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because Palau's reefs and its conservation leadership are a national pride and concern. Then the **international ring** — the conservation press, the partners, the world's media — because Palau's nature is globally valued and its example widely watched. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national and conservation rings are distinctly important** here, because they reinforce the community's case with the nation's own conservation story.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the science, the harm, the advocacy, the ban, the protection — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and honest; the proponent will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, science-and-reef-centred campaign is what fits Palau's conservation story and sustains a community cause. Verified, specific, science-grounded, and reef-focused — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that fits how Palau protects its nature.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, propose, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the state, the chiefs, the partners, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the science, the authority, and the protection.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant state / national authority

Subject: Request for information on [project]

We, [community/organisation], request the **permit, the plan, and the terms** for [project] at [place]. As the affected community, we are entitled to the record. Please provide the documents.

8B. Appeal to the State Government

To: the [state] government

Subject: Ban [harmful practice] to protect our reef

We, [community/organisation] of [state], present evidence that [project/practice] harms [our reef and fishery] through [sediment/runoff/clearing]. We ask the state to **ban [the practice] / refuse the permit** and protect the reef our community depends on, as [Airai state banned mangrove clearing].

8C. Appeal to the Traditional Leaders

To: the [traditional chiefs / Council of Chiefs]

Subject: Invoke our tradition to protect [place]

We, [community/organisation], ask our traditional leaders to protect [place], whose reef and fishery are harmed by [project]. We ask you to consider **bul** or your authority to halt the harm, as our tradition of the moratorium has long protected our resources.

8D. Request to Research & Conservation Partners

To: [research body / conservation NGO]

Subject: Help us document the harm from [project]

We are opposing [project], which we believe harms [our reef and fishery]. We seek your help to **document the harm scientifically** — the sediment, the runoff, the damage — so we can bring solid evidence to our state and chiefs, as reef science helped Airai protect its reef.

8E. Proposal for a Protected Area

To: the [state / Protected Areas Network]

Subject: Place [place] under lasting protection

We, [community/organisation], propose that [place] be placed under **community-owned protection** within the Protected Areas Network, to protect our watershed and reef for the future, as communities across Babeldaob have protected theirs.

8F. Appeal to the Proponent

To: [proponent] — its management

Subject: [Project] harms our reef and fishery

We, [community/organisation], inform you that [project] harms [our reef and fishery], as the science shows. We ask you to reconsider, and we are bringing the evidence to our state, our chiefs, and the public.

8G. Email to a Journalist

To: [journalist]

Subject: Story tip: a community using science to save its reef — [specific finding]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a story that fits Palau's conservation pride, with a clear hook: [evidence] shows [finding — e.g. "this clearing is smothering the reef we fish, and our community is asking the state to ban it"]. It echoes how Airai protected its reef. I can share the file and connect you with a fisher and a scientist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the community and the authorities

Subject: [Coalition] will protect [place] and its reef

We, [coalition], oppose [project], which the science shows harms our reef, our fish, and our water. As Airai used science to ban a harmful clearing and communities across Babeldaob protected their watersheds, we will bring the evidence to our state and chiefs, invoke our tradition of protection, and place our land under lasting care. Our reef sustains us, and we will protect it. We ask our leaders to act, and our neighbours to stand with us, as communities across our islands have acted to protect what sustains them.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, an appeal to the state or chiefs, or a proposal for protection is itself evidence. Keep them

factual, specific, and grounded in the science, the authority, and the protection; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the community, the research partners, and the leaders. The reply, or the result, becomes part of your record, and in Palau that record feeds the levers that matter most: the science, the state and traditional leaders, the tradition of local protection, and the land-and-reef link that protected Airai's reef.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a months-long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to protect the reef and the land. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Get the science started.** Ask a research body or partner to document the harm to the reef (Step 2, 8D).
- 2. Unite the community around the reef.** Make the land-and-reef case: this harms our fish and water (Step 3).
- 3. Take it to the state.** Ask the state government to ban the practice or refuse the permit (8B).
- 4. Take it to the chiefs.** Ask the traditional leaders to protect the resource, invoking bul (8C).
- 5. Propose lasting protection.** Ask that the area be placed under community-owned protection (8E).
- 6. Reach the press.** Take the science-and-reef story out (8G).
- 7. Persist, and value a local win.** A watershed protected is a real and lasting gain.

Do only the first three and you will have started the science, united the community, and taken the case to the state — the foundation of a Palauan campaign. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: get the science, unite the community, take it to the state and chiefs. A note for the resource-poor community in particular: in Palau the decisive moves are, fortunately, mostly within reach. Uniting the community around its reef, taking a concrete request to the state and the chiefs, and proposing a protected area cost mainly organising and persistence, not money; and the one real expense, the science, can often be supplied by Palau's research bodies and conservation partners, as reef scientists supplied the Airai case. What the fight demands above all is not resources but the willingness to gather the evidence and to work patiently through the community's own leaders. A community that starts the science, unites around its reef, and brings a clear request to its state and chiefs has already assembled the core of what protected Airai's reef — while holding honestly, throughout, to the knowledge that the win may be local and worth having even so.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Palau's system, with states close to their communities, real traditional authority, a proud tradition of conservation, and a place of honour in the international conservation world, offers a community real tools to protect its land and reefs — but it is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor grow discouraged.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. This is a **small nation** facing large forces — foreign investment, a flood of tourism, a changing climate — against which a single community's leverage is bounded. The community-driven wins

are **modest and local** — a state ban, a protected area — while the **biggest victories are led by national leaders and law**, so a community depends on winning supportive leaders and chiefs. And terrestrial protection has historically **lagged** behind marine protection, so the land can be cleared before the harm to the reef is felt. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes one community can stop a national mega-project, or that the land is as protected as the sea, will be disappointed — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to marshal the science, work through the state and chiefs, and establish lasting local protection.

What Still Works — And Some Is Strong

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, Palau's levers are real, and some are strong.

Solid science still persuades. Evidence of harm to the reef and fishery moves leaders and community, as it did in Airai.

State and traditional leaders still act. Authority close to the community can ban a practice or protect an area.

Local protection still holds. A community-owned protected area or a ban lasts, as the watershed areas do.

The land-and-reef link still convinces. Showing that protecting the land protects the fish is uniquely persuasive here.

Palau's conservation story still helps. The nation's pride and international standing reinforce a community's case.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Palau is realistic and clear-eyed: the wins are modest and local, the biggest are leader-led, and a small nation's leverage is limited — but the science, the state and traditional leaders, the tradition of local protection, and the land-and-reef link give a community real, and sometimes strong, levers, and protecting a watershed and a reef is a real and lasting victory. So diagnose your fight honestly: marshal the **science**; work through the **state and chiefs**; establish **lasting protection**; unite the **community**; make the **land-and-reef case**. Do not assume a destructive clearing cannot be banned; a community with good science banned one in Airai. And do not assume that because the land has been treated as less protected than the sea, it must stay that way: the whole thrust of the community conservation that protected Babeldaob's watersheds was to extend protection from the reef the people already valued to the land whose clearing was harming it. The lever is to carry the community's deep concern for the sea onto the land, showing that the two are one system and that protecting the watershed is protecting the reef.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Palau, like any nation, has had concerns about foreign money and the pressure of powerful interests — a foreign fishing lobby seeking to reopen protected waters, investors seeking land — so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the community's interest but by connected or foreign money, or advanced despite clear harm, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of a captured or heedless process. **Clear scientific harm ignored; a permit granted despite the damage to the reef; foreign money pressing to open protected land or water**, as a foreign fishing lobby has pressed to reopen Palau's waters; **the community's voice and the chiefs'**

authority bypassed; and **close ties** between the proponent, officials, and the powerful. Trace the project: how the permit was granted, who profits, and whether the science and the community were considered. In Palau, a project advanced despite clear harm to the reef the community depends on is worth examining for the interests behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the national government** can be pressed by foreign money or powerful investors. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **states**, close to their communities; the **traditional chiefs** and the **Council of Chiefs**, whose authority rests on custom and community; the **scientists** and research bodies, whose evidence is independent; the **Protected Areas Network** and the tradition of bul; and the **community** itself. Distinctively, the traditional authority of the chiefs and the independent science of the research bodies are checks that foreign money finds hard to reach. Your task is to document the harm and the process, and bring them to the states, the chiefs, the scientists, the press, and the community.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured or heedless project cannot be challenged. Instead, **document it precisely** — the scientific harm, the permit, the community ignored, the interest served — and take it to the forces that can act: the **states**; the **traditional chiefs**; the **scientists and partners**; the **press**; and the **community**. Pair the exposure with the science and the tradition of protection, so the harm and the remedy arrive together. In Palau, exposing a project advanced despite clear harm to the reef, and bringing solid science to the states and chiefs, is often the way to stop it — as the science of reef harm and the authority of the state banned the clearing in Airai and the chiefs' authority has defended Palau's protected waters. The pairing of the independent science and the customary authority is what makes this so hard for money to overcome: a foreign interest may sway a distant official, but it cannot easily buy the findings of independent reef scientists, nor override the legitimacy that the chiefs and the tradition of bul hold in Palauan society. A community that grounds its case in both — evidence money cannot fake and authority money cannot purchase — builds a defence against capture that is stronger than either alone. Do this with care, for challenging powerful interests invites pushback.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight, which turns on the science, the state and traditional leaders, the tradition of local protection, and the land-and-reef link.

Early (Months 0–3): The Science, the Community, and the Leaders

Pin down the project, the harm, and the deciders (Step 1); document the **science, the harm, and the land-and-reef link** (Step 2). Unite the **community** and connect it to the science (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); ask a **research partner** to document the harm (8D); appeal to the **state** (8B) and the **chiefs** (8C). This phase lays the foundation, and in Palau the science begun, the community united, and the leaders engaged here are what carry the fight.

Middle (Months): Science, Leaders, and Protection

Complete the science and sustain the community (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Carry the science to the **state and chiefs** (Step 4), propose **lasting protection** (8E), and build the **media drumbeat** that fits Palau's conservation story (Step 5). Each front

feeds the others. Do the time-critical things at once — the science before the clearing, the state ban before the permit is exercised — because the evidence and the authority you build early are what turn a project back.

Later (The Decision, and Vigilance): The Ban, the Protection, and Care

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **practice banned, the area protected, the reef defended** — and then stay vigilant, because, as Palau shows, terrestrial protection lags and new pressures arise. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a state banning a harmful clearing, as in Airai. Sometimes it is a watershed placed under community protection, as across Babeldaob. Each is a real, lasting victory — and each was won by a community that brought science to its own leaders, even if the scale was local.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-3	Start science + document harm Unite community Appeal to state + chiefs
MONTHS	Complete science Carry to state + chiefs Propose protection Media
DECISION	Practice banned / area protected Stay vigilant -- terrestrial protection lags

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Palau gives communities a real — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Solid science** of harm to the reefs and fish moves leaders and community alike, as reef science did in Airai. The **state governments and traditional chiefs**, close to the community, can ban a practice or protect an area. The tradition of **community-owned protection and bul** offers lasting, culturally-grounded protection. And the **land-and-reef link** — showing that protecting the land protects the sea — is a uniquely persuasive argument here. These are the tools that banned the clearing in Airai and protected the watersheds of Babeldaob.

The limits are just as real, and this guide states them first. The community-driven wins are **modest and local** — a state ban, a protected area — not the halting of a national mega-project. Palau's **biggest victories are leader-led**, so a community depends on winning supportive leaders and chiefs. And this is a **small nation** facing large forces, with limited leverage and much left partial. No guide should pretend these away; in Palau, the art is to marshal the science, work through the state and chiefs, establish lasting protection, and value what can be saved, because protecting a watershed and a reef is a real and lasting victory.

So the realistic promise is this: **marshal the science; work through the state and traditional leaders; establish lasting protection; unite the community; make the land-and-reef case — running all of it together**. Do that, and where the science is solid and the leaders reachable, you can ban a destructive practice and protect your land, as Airai and Babeldaob did; where the science is thin or the deciders distant, you can still win delay, a record, and the case made. Do it as they did — communities that used knowledge and custom to protect their reefs.

A last word on the science and the leaders. Palau's lesson is that a community armed with solid evidence, working through its own states and chiefs and its tradition of protection, can ban a destructive clearing and protect its watershed; but that the wins are modest and local, the biggest are leader-led, and a small nation's leverage is limited. The powerful count on your believing that the permit is granted, that the leaders have decided, and that nothing can be done. Their advantage is the money, the speed of the clearing, and the lag in protecting the land. Yours is the science that shows the harm, the states and chiefs close to your

community, the tradition of protection and bul, the reef your families depend on, and the proven fact that a community used reef science to ban a harmful clearing and protect its watershed. Play to that. Keep the record and the science, unite the community, win the state and the chiefs, establish the protection, and treat every study completed, every leader persuaded, and every area protected as a lasting gain, even when the whole cannot be won at once.

The tools are here, and the Airai and Babeldaob communities proved them — modestly and honestly: reef science that showed how clearing the land smothered the reefs and cut the catch; a community that carried that evidence to its own state government until the clearing of mangroves was banned; and communities across the largest island that, drawing on the tradition of bul and the model of community-owned protection, established watershed protected areas that hold today — even as Palau's terrestrial protection still lags behind its famous seas and a small nation faces forces far larger than itself. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the solidity of the science, the closeness of the states and chiefs to the community, the strength of a tradition of protection, and the reef the people will not see destroyed — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin with the science and the community and the reef, and build from there. Communities before you have used knowledge and custom to protect their land and their reefs. What Airai and Babeldaob won — a harmful clearing banned and watersheds placed under lasting protection — can be won again by others who bring the science and work through their leaders. So, in time and with patience, can yours.